

I'll isolate 1300–1399 and keep the same discipline: no later suicide meanings, no sixteenth-century Fuji-kō material unless it is clearly only contextual. The probable centre now becomes early Fuji ascent, medieval shrine-temple organisation, Yoshida/Murayama route formation, and the still-backgrounded lava forest/lake perimeter.

Thought for 46s >

Fourteenth century only — **1300–1399** — gives a very specific answer:

Aokigahara itself is still culturally silent. Fuji is not.

That is the decisive distinction. In the fourteenth century, the later “suicide forest” does not exist as a recorded cultural object. The dominant record is not about entering Aokigahara; it is about **ascending Fuji**, organising routes, lodging pilgrims, and converting a formerly terrifying volcano into a climbable sacred mountain. The forest is physically there, but the named religious and social energy is concentrated on **routes, lakes, shrines, Shugendō, lodging, and the summit**.

So the fourteenth-century root is not “death forest”. It is:

from remote worship to managed ascent.

1. The forest exists, but the sources do not yet make it the protagonist

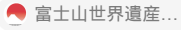
By 1300, Aokigahara had existed for roughly 430 years after the 864 Jōgan eruption. The old Seno-umi lake had already been split and partly buried by lava, producing the later Saiko/Shōjiko configuration and the lava ground on which the forest grew. Yamanashi's guide describes the 864 Aokigahara lava flow as burying much of old Seno-umi and creating Saiko and Shōjiko; it also frames Aokigahara as a forest grown on that lava surface.  Yamanashi Pref...

But in fourteenth-century cultural terms, the forest is **background terrain**. It is not yet “樹海” as the later national death-symbol. It is the dark, rough, lava-grown north-western foot of Fuji, bordering the lake-world. The record we can actually stand on is about Fuji worship, not Aokigahara suicide.

That absence is itself evidence. If Aokigahara had already been a famous fourteenth-century suicide/death destination, we would expect some trace in pilgrimage, shrine, road, temple, or later local-historical summaries. The accessible record instead points to Fuji ascent and sacred-route formation.

2. The fourteenth-century transformation: Fuji becomes climbable for non-specialists

The single most important fourteenth-century development is that Fuji worship moves beyond elite ascetics and becomes more accessible to lay believers.

The Fujisan World Heritage Center says that from the fourteenth century onward, lay believers called 道者 appeared among ordinary people, climbing Fuji in the hope of rebirth in the Pure Land; it also says 御師 — religious guides/lodging-providers — became active in guiding and caring for them. 

This is the century's deep psychological fact.

The relevant emotional grammar is not “I want to vanish into the trees.” It is:

I want salvation.

I want rebirth.

I climb the sacred mountain.

I move through a guided religious route.

That is a completely different death relation from modern Aokigahara. Fourteenth-century death is about **afterlife hope**, not private disappearance.

3. The word-world is 道者, 御師, 宿坊 — not 樹海

The fourteenth-century vocabulary matters.

The later Aokigahara world is dominated by words like 樹海, 自殺, 行方不明, 発見, 声かけ, パトロール.

The fourteenth-century Fuji world is dominated by:

道者 — pilgrims/believers;

御師 — guides, ritual mediators, lodging-providers;

宿坊 — pilgrim lodgings;

登拝 — devotional ascent;

極楽浄土 — Pure Land rebirth;

修験 — mountain ascetic practice.

This matters because the fourteenth-century structure is still social. Pilgrims are not trying to become unfindable. They are being guided, housed, ritually handled, and placed inside a recognised salvation route.

4. Late fourteenth century: Yoshida route infrastructure emerges

The north-side Yoshida route is crucial because it is the Fuji-access system geographically closest to the later Aokigahara/Saiko/Kawaguchiko world.

Fujiyoshida's official World Heritage page says the **Yoshida-guchi climbing route** starts at Kitaguchi Hongū Fuji Sengen Shrine and aims for the summit; by the **late fourteenth century**, lodgings for pilgrims had begun to appear, and facilities for large numbers of climbers were being prepared. 

This is a hard fourteenth-century hinge. By the late 1300s, Fuji is no longer only a distant sacred cone or an ascetic mountain. It is becoming an **organised climb**.

That matters for Aokigahara because it tells us what “entering Fuji nature” meant in this century. It meant:

route;
guide;
lodging;
ascent;
summit;
religious goal;
return.

Not lone disappearance.

5. The north-foot is moving towards managed pilgrimage, not anti-social exit

This is the key inversion.

The later Aokigahara script is:

road → forest edge → off-path → disappearance.

The late-fourteenth-century Yoshida script is:

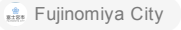
shrine → lodging → guide → climbing route → summit → salvation/rebirth.

That is why the fourteenth century is so important. It gives the **opposite** of the modern suicide-forest structure. It gives managed entry into sacred nature, not unmanaged exit from society.

The forest will later become powerful precisely because it sits off that script. But in the fourteenth century, the script itself is still being built.

6. Southern Fuji: Murayama Shugendō is already gathering ascetics in the early 1300s

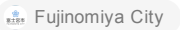
The southern side gives the other major fourteenth-century religious infrastructure.

Fujinomiya's page on the Ōmiya/Murayama route says that by the **early fourteenth century**, Shugendō practitioners training on Fuji are thought to have gathered around Murayama as a base. It also says that in the medieval period, many pilgrims climbed under the guidance of ascetics and 先達; later visual materials such as the Fuji Mandala show pilgrims ascending from the Ōmiya/Murayama route. 

This is huge because it means that, in the early fourteenth century, Fuji is being institutionalised from below by ascetic bases. The mountain is not a blank wilderness. It is being organised by religious specialists.

Again, this cuts against later Aokigahara mythology. The medieval sacred mountain is not “go in and get lost.” It is “enter through the proper religious gate.”

7. Fourteenth-century Fuji is still a Buddhist-Shugendō mountain

Fujinomiya's broader faith-history page says that once eruptions had quietened from around the twelfth century, Fuji became a Shugendō mountain, combining older Japanese mountain worship with esoteric Buddhism and Daoist/immortality currents. The summit was understood, through honji-suijaku thought, as a Buddhist world or a place where Buddhist beings appeared in kami form. 

This is another important correction. The fourteenth-century Fuji world is not yet Edo-period Fuji-kō in the full sense, and it is not modern sightseeing. It is still strongly **Buddhist-Shugendō**.

So the death relation is Buddhist. People climb with concern for rebirth, salvation, karmic purification, and access to a sacred summit. The later forest of self-erasure is not present.

8. 1384: the Subashiri hanging Buddha is the century's sharpest material object

The most precise fourteenth-century artefact is the **1384 kakebotoke** / 懸仏 from the Subashiri route.

Yamanashi tourism material says a hanging Buddha dated **1384** was found along the Subashiri route, and describes it as the oldest surviving example of an offering to Fuji.

 Fuji-san World Heritage Center likewise notes that a kakebotoke with a 1384 inscription was excavated from the seventh station area of the Subashiri route. 

This is one of the most important pieces of evidence because it is not just a later story about pilgrimage. It is a material devotional deposit.

What does it say?

It says that by 1384, someone was making or depositing Buddhist-style votive material on Fuji's climbing route. The mountain was not merely seen; it was **offered to**. It had become a ritual field where objects, bodies and hopes were placed into a sacred vertical route.

Again, the direction is vertical ascent, not horizontal forest disappearance.

9. 1384 also tells us where the named energy is not

The kakebotoke was from the Subashiri route, not Aokigahara. That matters.

The fourteenth-century evidence clusters around:

Subashiri route;
Yoshida route;
Murayama route;
Kitaguchi Hongū Fuji Sengen Shrine;
Murayama ascetic base;
pilgrim lodging;
mountain ascent.

It does **not** cluster around Aokigahara as a named death-place.

This is why a strict fourteenth-century answer cannot be "Aokigahara was already death-haunted." The evidence says the opposite: the sacred infrastructure is being built around ways **up** Fuji, not ways **into** the forest.

10. The Aokigahara lake-margin is still present, but thinly documented for this century

Saiko, Shōji and Motosu are physically there. The lava flow had already split the old lake system centuries earlier. These lakes will later become crucial in Fuji-kō's **Inner Eight Seas** pilgrimage world, and modern World Heritage material identifies Shōji and Motosu as Inner Eight Seas pilgrimage sites for Fuji-kō believers.  富士山世界遺産...

But we have to be exact: that does not prove a named fourteenth-century Aokigahara lake pilgrimage system in the same form. The strong documentary link to Kakugyō's water-practice lake list comes in 1580, outside this century.  Minobu Town

So for the fourteenth century, the safest formulation is:

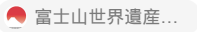
The Saiko–Shōji–Motosu lake world existed beside Aokigahara, but the clearly evidenced fourteenth-century religious energy is centred on Fuji ascent routes, not on Aokigahara or the later Inner Eight Seas system.

That restraint matters. Otherwise we contaminate the century with later Fuji-kō material.

11. What “death” means in the fourteenth century

This is the deepest point.

Fourteenth-century Fuji is absolutely death-adjacent, but not in the Aokigahara way.

The World Heritage Center says lay believers from the fourteenth century climbed hoping for 極楽浄土への往生 — rebirth in the Pure Land. 

That is death-related, but it is not suicide. It is not self-erasure. It is not hiding the body. It is a religious technology for facing death through salvation.

So the fourteenth-century death grammar is:

death as karmic problem;
death as afterlife transition;
mountain ascent as salvation route;
summit as Buddhist/kami realm;
pilgrimage as embodied hope for rebirth.

Modern Aokigahara death grammar is:

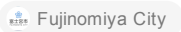
death as exit;
forest as concealment;
body as unfindable;
social self as erased;
others as spared or abandoned.

Those are profoundly different structures.

12. Fourteenth-century “otherworld” is above, not inside

This is the cleanest conceptual distinction.

In modern Aokigahara, the otherworld is inward: you enter the trees, the forest closes, the path is lost, the person disappears.

In fourteenth-century Fuji, the otherworld is upward: you climb from the foot through a route system to a summit understood as sacred/Buddhist/kami space. Fujinomiya’s faith-history page says the summit was recognised as a Buddhist world or as a place where Buddhas appeared as kami. 

So the directionality is different:

fourteenth century: ascent to salvation;
twentieth century: lateral entry into disappearance.

This is not a small difference. It is the whole history.

13. The century's social form: guided, housed, collective

Fourteenth-century Fuji ascent is not primarily solitary.

The sources repeatedly imply mediation: 道者, 御師, 宿坊, 修験者, 先達. The Fujisan World Heritage Center says ordinary believers called 道者 appeared from the fourteenth century, while 御師 guided and cared for them.  富士山世界遺産... Fujiyoshida says pilgrim lodgings began to appear on the Yoshida route by the late fourteenth century.

 Fujiyoshida City Fujinomiya says pilgrims climbed under the guidance of ascetics and sendatsu in the medieval period.  Fujinomiya City

This is decisive.

The later Aokigahara image is solitary. The fourteenth-century Fuji ascent is mediated and collective. The person is not trying to drop out of society. They are entering a religious society of movement.

14. The local north-foot settlement layer is still mostly just outside the century

For Shōji, Motosu, Saiko, and the Kuisiki world, our clearest local documentary hooks begin in the sixteenth century: 1545 Motosu in diplomatic travel, 1554 Shōji mortuary record, 1577 Shōji commercial exemption, 1597 Saiko/Nishi-no-umi runaway-peasant recall. Those are valuable, but not fourteenth-century evidence.

So the honest fourteenth-century answer must say:

For Aokigahara-adjacent village life specifically, the open source record is much thinner in 1300–1399 than in 1500–1599. The century's solid evidence is Fuji ascent infrastructure, not Aokigahara village documentation.

That is not a weakness. It is what the source horizon says.

15. What Aokigahara is, by negative reconstruction

If we reconstruct only what is safe:

By the fourteenth century, Aokigahara is:

a several-hundred-year-old lava forest;
beside the already-formed Saiko/Shōjiko lake system;
near the north-western Fuji foot;
outside the main named ascent infrastructure;
physically difficult, forested, cave/lava terrain;

not yet a documented suicide place;
not yet a documented national “tree sea” death-image.

Its cultural status is best described as **peripheral sacred terrain**: not central enough to dominate records, but inside the larger Fuji world that is becoming intensely religiously organised.

16. What the fourteenth century contributes to later Aokigahara

It contributes **contrast**, not direct origin.

Later Aokigahara takes the old Fuji pattern of leaving ordinary space and inverts it.

Fourteenth-century pattern:

leave ordinary life;
enter guided pilgrimage;
climb;
seek salvation/rebirth;
return or complete religious merit.

Modern Aokigahara pattern:

leave ordinary life;
avoid guidance;
enter unguided forest;
seek disappearance;
do not return.

The modern forest is powerful partly because it is an anti-pilgrimage: the movement into Fuji’s sacred nature remains, but the salvific structure collapses.

17. The best fourteenth-century source hierarchy

For this century, the ranked source base is:

1. Yoshida-guchi route / late-fourteenth-century lodgings.

Best north-foot evidence for organised pilgrimage infrastructure emerging near the later Aokigahara world.  Fujiyoshida City

2. Fujisan World Heritage Center on fourteenth-century 道者 and 御師.

Best concise statement that ordinary believers appear from the fourteenth century, climbing for Pure Land rebirth, with guides/caretakers active.  富士山世界遺産...

3. Subashiri 1384 kakebotoke.

Best material object from the century: a dated Buddhist offering to Fuji.

4. Murayama route early-fourteenth-century Shugendō gathering.

Best evidence for the southern ascetic base and medieval guided pilgrimage pattern.

 Fujinomiya City

5. Fujinomiya faith-history page on summit Buddhist/kami world and route formation.

Best synthesis of the religious directionality: Fuji as Shugendō mountain, summit as Buddhist/kami realm, routes opening in the fourteenth–fifteenth centuries.

 Fujinomiya City

6. Geological/lake formation material.

Necessary background for Aokigahara's physical existence, but not evidence of fourteenth-century death discourse.  Yamanashi Pref...

Final fourteenth-century thesis

In the fourteenth century, Aokigahara is not a suicide forest and not yet the main object of cultural meaning. It is the forested lava margin of a Fuji world whose central transformation is the rise of organised devotional ascent.

The century's key facts are: ordinary believers called 道者 begin climbing Fuji for Pure Land rebirth; 御師 and 宿坊 begin to support them; the Yoshida route develops pilgrim lodging by the late fourteenth century; Murayama gathers ascetics by the early fourteenth century; and the 1384 Subashiri kakebotoke proves devotional offering on Fuji routes. The “death” present in this century is not self-erasure but salvation: death faced through rebirth, Buddhist-kami summit cosmology, and embodied ascent.

So the exact answer is:

Fourteenth-century Fuji gives ascent, not disappearance. It gives Pure Land hope, not quiet self-erasure. It gives guided pilgrimage, not solitary vanishing.

Aokigahara's later power comes partly from inverting that medieval structure: the old movement out of ordinary life remains, but the route, guide, lodging, summit and salvation are removed, leaving only entry into hard nature and non-return.